

https://www.somdnews.com/independent/news/local/charles-school-system-considers-ai-in-district/article_a78ca3e0-53b3-4c2b-ab1d-b852c2c0328d.html

Charles school system considers AI in district

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Ilana Williams  Southern Maryland News

Charles public schools could have new guidelines for using artificial intelligence in classrooms.

In June 2024, the school system created a task force made up of school administrators, staff, teachers, parents and students to discuss AI resources and policies to determine what could be used in schools, Lora Bennett, executive director of information technology strategy, said.

AI offers personalized learning, Charmaine Thompson, director of instructional technology, said during the Charles County school board meeting on Aug. 12.

The county is experiencing a teacher shortage and AI could help students understand subjects like math and English better, she said. It could also engage the county's non-native English speaking students and learning experiences.

"But it does not replace the teacher," Thompson said. "You still have to have that human interaction."

AI teaches technology how to think and respond like a human, Thompson said. It learns through data that users input and gets "smarter" over time. The more users in the AI tools, the smarter it gets.

It's more popular now because of generative AI, which can generate images, music and virtually anything else off of user input, like ChatGPT, Google Gemini and Microsoft CoPilot, Thompson said. Along with generative AI, intelligent tutoring systems are becoming more prominent in school districts.

"Imagine having a digital tool for every student," Thompson said. "These systems are very powerful because they are one-on-one and are catered to that student."

Adaptive learning systems, like Khan Academy's Khanmingo, can teach students lessons. For instance, if a student is learning a math equation and the student gets it wrong, it tells the tutoring system to keep providing lessons or breaks down the question.

“Sometimes we teach one size fits all and we know that doesn’t work,” school board member Dottery Butler-Washington said during the board meeting. “But we struggle to find different ways to teach our students. This is a tool that we can benefit from.”

School administrators can also use predictive analytics to predict how a student will do in school, Thompson said. It provides data on their attendance, grades and behavior and provides strategies in certain areas.

While concerns about using AI for unethical reasons and grading challenges remain, it could reduce administration tasks that would not require someone to check for accuracy, Nicole Kreamer, school board vice chairperson, said.

“We need to continue to stay aggressive as it evolves,” Kreamer said. “It’s really complex, but we can’t run from it. It’s here.”

To address the risks of AI, like misuse and misinformation, the guidelines offer ethical and responsible integration of AI into the school district, Bennett said. That includes when teachers, students and staff can and cannot use AI.

For instance, a teacher cannot use AI to assign a grade but can use it to recommend books or articles, Bennett said. A student can use it for personalized studying but can’t use it to generate or submit work.

“We are committed to continually develop our guidance based on best practices,” Thompson said. “It’s imperative to educate our students and our parents.”
